

Incident Alert 0014. TLP Green.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	DE, FR, BE – Unlabelled Ads discrediting Qatar targeting capitals of France, Belgium and Germany using hijacked FB page	24/06/2024	1

Summary

- 8 unlabelled political ads claiming Qatar is funding and organising pro-Palestine demonstrations launched by an anonymous Facebook page.
- The ads has so far reached around 216k users in Berlin, Brussels, and Paris – targeting European seats of power.
- The ads are still running.
- The page used to deliver the ads is likely hijacked.
- We have identified a similar case in a past investigation
- Platforms and European governments have been contacted and we will continue monitoring to identify the threat actor behind the operation.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

On June 23, 8 unlabelled political ads with a video claiming that Qatar is funding and organising pro-Palestine demonstrations, was published by the Facebook page The Cover Up ([1](#), [2](#), [3](#), [4](#), [5](#), [6](#), [7](#), [8](#)). The ads, which are still active, use Facebook, Instagram, and Meta Audience Network to target the capitals of France, Germany, and Belgium.

The page was created in 2017 and had only posted a few posts before being taken over and rebranded on June 23, 2024. The country of the account administering the page is hidden and the video is not found anywhere else. Two of the ads are not labelled as targeting Europe. Meta is not providing any data on these ads.

Qatar has been targeted in the past, using the same ad and video format in the past (IA 0013).

Narrative

Meta narrative: Qatar has a plot against Europe.

Sub-narratives: Qatar is funding and organising pro-Palestine protests.

Impact

Reach: Around Berlin: 11K, Brussels: 40k, Paris: 165K

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Smear](#) – Smearing the reputation of the Qatar.

[Deliver Ads](#) – Using ads to reach their target audience without revealing the ads' funding source.

[Conceal network identity](#) - the page seems to be hiding its true identity and affiliations.

[Acquire Compromised Account](#) – Likely acquired a compromised account to post the ads.

Recommendations

- Action taken: Case reported to Meta (24/06/2024 16:51), European Institutions, and EU member states affected.
- Continue to monitor – We need to continue monitoring for similar ads and try to attribute the actor behind them.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Palestine, Muslims, Qatar	N/A	Saman Nazari , A4E Rikard Friberg von Sydow, Södertörn University	Video, Ad	Facebook, Instagram, Meta Audience Network